

A Valentinian Exposition, with On the Anointing, On Baptism A and B, and On the Eucharist A and B

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Editor's Introduction

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A Valentinian Exposition expounds the origin of the creation and the process of redemption in terms of Valentinian theology, specifically in terms of the myth of Sophia. The tractate thus offers the only original Valentinian account of that myth: *The Tripartite Tractate* (I,5) recounts another version that features the Logos instead of Sophia.

The author begins by promising to reveal “my mystery,” and follows the account with baptismal and eucharistic prayers and benedictions. This suggests that *A Valentinian Exposition* offers a kind of secret catechism for candidates being initiated into gnosis. Following the revelation of the mystery, the candidate is invited to participate in anointing, baptism, and the eucharist, as Gnostic Christians understand these sacraments.

Besides relating the Sophia myth and referring to sacramental rituals, *A Valentinian Exposition* has a third remarkable feature: it gives firsthand evidence of theological controversies among different groups of Valentinian theologians. The heresiologists attest that gnostic teachers disagree among themselves on the interpretation of fundamental doctrines; thus *A Valentinian Exposition* demonstrates the truth of Tertullian's statement that Valentinian Christians “disagree on many specific issues, even with their own founders” (*Praescr.* 42). Irenaeus, Hippolytus, and others mention several such issues involving the story of Sophia: the interpretation of the primordial source (in what sense is it monadic or dyadic), of Limit (what are his functions) and the passion of Sophia (what motivated it). While the church fathers sketch out various positions taken on these issues, the author of *A Valentinian Exposition* engages each issue, challenging certain views and advocating others.

Valentinian theologians disagreed, first of all, on the question of whether the primordial root of all is a monad or a dyad. According to Irenaeus, Valentinus himself and the followers of his student Ptolemy said that the primal source is a dyad consisting of the Father of the All and his feminine counterpart, Silence, the Mother of all things (*Haer.* 1.11.1). But this author insists, on the contrary, that the Father is one, singular, a monad; and that the Silence, far from being the Father's dyadic syzygy, was merely the state of tranquility in which the Father reposed in his original solitude.

Second, this author discusses the function of Limit: he himself maintains that Limit possesses four powers, while other Valentinians attribute to Limit only two of those four powers. As this author interprets the story, Limit first separated Sophia's passion from the pleroma, and so pro-

tected and confirmed the aeons against the violation her transgression incurred. Yet Limit also restrained Sophia from being absorbed into the Father, and, finally, he separated her passions from her and confirmed her as well.

A third issue of controversy among Valentinian theologians concerned the interpretation of Sophia's suffering. According to Irenaeus' account, some Valentinians said that Sophia, in transgressing her role in the pleroma, only expressed the involuntary longing of all the aeons for closer communion with the Father (*Haer.* 1.2.2); others said that she willfully and audaciously attempted to rise above the condition of interdependence she shared in common with all the other aeons, and dared to imitate the Father himself (*Haer.* 1.2.3). The author of *A Valentinian Exposition* apparently takes a position closer to the latter view, which indicates that Sophia willfully violated the pleromic harmony, and later repented of this as she turned back to the Father.

This text goes on to describe how Sophia, after suffering in isolation, repented and received Christ, who descended to become her divine counterpart. Their divine reunion demonstrates the Father's will that "nothing ... happen in the pleroma apart from a syzygy" (i.e., that all beings except himself be interdependent); and shows how all things "will come to be in unity and reconciliation."

Finally, this text offers what appear to be liturgical fragments of a Valentinian celebration of baptism and the eucharist: in this respect, as in others mentioned above, the text offers a unique and valuable opportunity to investigate various forms of Valentinian thought and ritual practice.